

Long vowel sounds

A vowel can sound long, or stretched. For example, the word *alien* has a long “a” sound at the beginning of the word and the grapheme that represents this sound is *a*. A more complex word, such as *monkey*, has a long “e” sound in its second syllable and the grapheme is *ey*.

• The letter **y** is a **consonant** when it is the **first letter of a syllable that has more than one letter**, such as *yellow*. If *y* is anywhere else in the syllable, it acts like a vowel: In the word *trendy*, it sounds like an “e.”

a

▷ Long “a”

This sound is represented by the graphemes *a*, *ai*, *aigh*, *ay*, *a-e*, *ei*, *eigh*, and *ey*.

apron

snail

straight

ray

snake

reindeer

sleigh

they

e

▷ Long “e”

This sound is represented by the graphemes *e*, *ea*, *ee*, *ei*, *ey*, *e-e*, *ie*, and *y*.

he

beaver

cheetah

ceiling

donkey

these

thief

smelly

i

▷ Long “i”

This sound is represented by the graphemes *i*, *eigh*, *l*, *ie*, *igh*, *i-e*, *y*, *ye*, and *y-e*.

bison

height

l

pie

night

pike

fly

eye

type

o

▷ Long “o”

This sound is represented by the graphemes *o*, *oa*, *oe*, *ol*, *ou*, *ough*, *ow*, and *o-e*.

cobra

goat

toe

folk

soul

dough

crow

antelope

u

▷ Long “u”

This sound is represented by the graphemes *u*, *ew*, *ue*, and *u-e*.

unicorn

chew

barbecue

use

Complex vowel sounds

In addition to short and long vowel sounds, there are also complex vowel sounds in English. For example, the grapheme *oo* makes two different sounds depending on the word: a short vowel sound, as in the word *hook*, or a long vowel sound, as in the word *loot*.

Complex vowel sound	Examples
aw	awful, author
oi	toil, annoy
ow	house, cow
oo (short)	look, put
oo (long)	moot, suit